

The Waterfront Brief

Weekly sustainment intelligence for naval shipyard leadership · Naval shipbuilding, ship repair, and fleet sustainment

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Five items. The Department tore up its collective bargaining agreements on twenty-four hours' notice, including at Portsmouth, and is now defending that in court. The Navy has decided that sailors should not be painting and insulating during a carrier's midlife overhaul, and has put 690,000 contracted labour hours behind that view with five more contracts due. Then: the \$448 million data programme arriving at the nuclear yards, a maintenance centre printing a part for \$131 that the supply system prices at \$300,000, and the fifth public shipyard, rejected in 2022, now pushed by the budget office.

Labels: FACT is attributed to the named source in the same sentence; Assessment is this desk's analysis, built only on facts stated above it; Speculation is flagged as such; Unverified marks a claim this desk could not check against a primary source, with the reason given.

WATERFRONT OPS & PRODUCTION

Deckplate: the grievance process went away in twenty-four hours

FACT: a memorandum signed by the Secretary on April 9, 2026 directs "the termination of all collective bargaining agreements to which the Department is a party, not subject to a court order enjoining implementation of Executive Order (EO) 14251... within 24 hours of the date of this memorandum," excepting a population certified in the Federal Register in April 2025 and "the local employing offices of any agency police officers, security guards, or firefighters." A collective bargaining agreement is the contract between an agency and a union that fixes working conditions and, crucially for a shipyard, the grievance procedure — the route by which a disputed discipline, assignment or safety call gets adjudicated.

FACT: Maine Public reported on April 20, 2026 that the terminations covered two unions representing "several hundred workers at the Portsmouth Naval Shipyard," quoting American Federation of Government Employees national vice president David Gonzalez: "When you take away collective bargaining, there's no grievance process." FACT: the same report quotes Portsmouth Metal Trades Council president Alana Schaeffer saying her union's

agreement "is shielded for now by a court injunction."

FACT: Government Executive reported on July 22, 2026 that two federal employee unions asked a judge for a preliminary injunction restoring their agreements, arguing not that the executive order is unlawful but that the Secretary failed the "reasoned decision-making" standard of the Administrative Procedure Act and "did not point to any facts showing that any of plaintiffs' CBAs, much less all of them, were inconsistent with national security."

Assessment: the shape of that legal argument is what makes this a scheduling matter and not only a labour one. As reported, the unions are not asking a court to rule the executive order unlawful; they are challenging how the termination was carried out. A challenge aimed at the manner of a decision leaves the decision itself available to the government, so a win for the unions need not be permanent. For a production planner that means the grievance route's availability is a variable rather than a constant, and it already differs between bargaining units at one yard: Portsmouth has a council shielded by an injunction alongside two whose agreements were terminated.

Bottom line: find out, unit by unit, which of your yard's bargaining agreements are terminated and which sit behind an injunction, because the answer differs inside one shipyard and a terminated agreement removes the negotiated route without this desk having established what statutory process replaces it.

Sources: Secretary of Defense memorandum, "Termination of Certain Collective Bargaining Agreements," Apr 9, 2026; Maine Public, Apr 20, 2026; Government Executive, Jul 22, 2026 {.sources}

OPERATIONS & READINESS

MAINTENANCE

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The Navy just moved 690,000 hours of painting and preservation off the crew

FACT: a Navy release of June 15, 2026 states that the Navy Quality of Service Cross-Functional Team and PAE Maritime's In-Service Aircraft Carrier Program Office "are changing how the Navy does business for the execution of aircraft carrier Refueling and Complex Overhaul (RCOH), beginning with USS Harry S. Truman (CVN 75)"; that sailors on a carrier in that overhaul traditionally performed

“supplementary, non-rate-specific duties such as painting, insulating, transportation services, and maintenance”; and that using commercial contracts for that work “will potentially return up to one million man-hours to the crew.” A refuelling and complex overhaul is the once-in-a-lifetime refit at the midpoint of a carrier’s fifty-year service life, which is why the crew is alongside for years rather than weeks.

FACT: the same release states that “to date, five Navy contracts have returned approximately 690,000 labor hours to the crew, with plans to award five additional contracts over the next five years,” and that the approach “allows for optimized, smaller crew sizes.”

FACT: USNI News reported on June 12, 2026 that “as of Thursday, the switch to contractors has cost about \$32 million,” and that HII’s Newport News Shipbuilding is performing the overhaul.

Assessment: this is the part worth acting on, and it is not the quality-of-life framing. A service has decided in writing that ship’s force is not the labour pool for preservation, insulation and transportation during a shipyard period, and has put contracts behind that decision with five more scheduled over five years.

That work is going to firms other than the prime, and the award record shows it.

FACT: federal award records at USASpending show contract N0002424C2101, worth \$17.6 million and held by Mills Marine & Ship Repair LLC, described as “THIRD PARTY FIRE WATCH SUPPORT FOR CVN 74 AND, IF OPTIONS ARE EXERCISED, CVN 75 RCOH,” running from October 2023 to October 2026. FACT: the same record codes that award as having received five offers. Fire watch is the standing watch kept on a compartment while hot work is done in it, and it is a classic ship’s-force duty. FACT: the same records show contract N0002424C2106 with Huntington Ingalls Inc, described as “CVN 75 RCOH ADVANCE PLANNING,” at \$1.22 billion.

Assessment: those two records are the argument. One is the prime holding the billion-dollar planning scope; the other is a small marine repair company holding a \$17.6 million watch-standing contract on the same class of availability, with the Truman overhaul written into it as an option — and five firms bid for it. That is a concrete demonstration that this workstream reaches beyond the prime, and that there is a field competing for it, rather than an inference about what primes want.

Assessment, on the two numbers, because the release carries both and they are not the same claim. “Approximately 690,000 labor hours” is what five awarded contracts have delivered; “up to one million man-hours” is what the approach might reach. One is a count, the other a ceiling, and quoting the larger

figure as achieved would be the ordinary way to get this wrong.

Assessment on price, offered as arithmetic rather than a rate: \$32 million against 690,000 hours works out near \$46 an hour. The release does not say the money and the hours cover the same scope or period, so treat that as indicative and not a billing rate — but it is the only public number that puts a price on this work.

FACT: USNI News reported in January 2024 that HII’s Newport News Shipbuilding was awarded a contract with “total potential value of \$913 million” for advanced procurement for Truman’s overhaul, and that overhauls of this kind “account for about a third of the Newport News’ business.”

Assessment: set against \$1.22 billion of advance planning, a \$17.6 million watch-standing contract is a rounding error on the overhaul and the whole point for anyone who is not Newport News. The counter-evidence angle came back empty — this desk found no source arguing the shift is a bad idea or that it will not hold — so nothing here has been tested against a critic. **Speculation, flagged as such:** the obvious risk is that contracted preservation in an occupied shipyard is harder to schedule than crew labour you already own. This desk has no evidence either way.

Bottom line: a named, recurring, non-nuclear workstream now exists at carrier overhauls, with five more contracts due over five years and at least one already held by a small repair firm rather than the prime — so the vehicle to watch is the third-party support contract, not the overhaul award.

Sources: Navy release, “Rethinking Sailors and CVN RCOH,” Jun 15, 2026; USNI News, Jun 12, 2026; Federal News Network, Jul 2, 2026; USNI News, Jan 26, 2024; Award N0002424C2101, Mills Marine & Ship Repair; Award N0002424C2106, Huntington Ingalls {sources}

MAINTENANCE ENGINEERING & TECHNOLOGIES

A \$448 million data programme, and the two numbers being used to sell it

FACT: a Navy release of December 9, 2025 states the Navy is investing \$448 million in a programme called Ship OS, built on software from the company Palantir, announced by Navy Secretary John Phelan at the first Department of the Navy Rapid Capabilities Office industry day; that it is “managed by the Maritime Industrial Base (MIB) Program in collaboration with Naval Sea Systems Command”; and that it “will aggregate data from enterprise resource planning systems, legacy databases, and operational sources

to identify bottlenecks.” An enterprise resource planning system is the business software a yard runs its labour, material and scheduling records in, and the programme reads across those systems rather than replacing them.

FACT: the same release states that during pilot deployments “at General Dynamics Electric Boat, submarine schedule planning was reduced from 160 manual hours to under 10 minutes, while Portsmouth Naval Shipyard cut material review times from weeks to under one hour,” and that the initial investment “will focus on Submarine Industrial Base shipbuilders, shipyards, and critical suppliers.”

Assessment, on those two numbers. Each is a single reading of a single task at a single site, reported by the parties announcing the programme. Neither comes with the spread it was drawn from: how long that task ran at its best and worst before, how often it ran, what share of a planner’s year it took. A number with no run of data behind it cannot tell you whether a process changed or a good week got written down. That is not a reason to disbelieve them; it is a reason not to plan against them.

FACT: Breaking Defense reported on December 10, 2025 that officials said the system “would be proliferated through three of the public shipyards and some private shipyards,” and quoted a Navy spokesman: “The Navy intends to start with ShipOS at our nuclear shipyards and our nuclear repair yards.” FACT: DefenseScoop reported on December 23, 2025 that the work “involves a shared-savings contract mechanism, where Palantir’s payout is tied to the products’ impact and metrics.”

Assessment: a shared-savings arrangement means the vendor is paid out of the improvement it is measured as having produced. That makes the baseline — what the yard’s performance is deemed to have been before the software arrived — a commercial term, not just an analytical one. **Unverified:** this desk found no public description of how that baseline is set or who audits it, having read only the announcement release and three trade reports of it. For a yard whose own records are the input, it is the term to read first.

Bottom line: treat the 160-hours-to-10-minutes figure as a demonstration rather than a rate, work out whether you are inside the nuclear-first wave or the undated expansion after it, and read the baseline definition in any shared-savings arrangement that touches your records.

Sources: Navy release, Dec 9, 2025; USNI News, Dec 9, 2025; Breaking Defense, Dec 10, 2025; DefenseScoop, Dec 23, 2025 {sources}

Printing the part nobody will sell you, and the line the Navy drew around it

FACT: a NAVSEA release of August 11, 2025 states that when a chilled water pump cooling rotor used on an Arleigh Burke-class destroyer needed replacement, Southeast Regional Maintenance Center at Mayport found the six-blade part “not available to purchase separately in the Navy supply system,” so that correcting the deficiency “typically requires the purchase of an entirely new pump,” and that the team instead “manufacture[d] four progressively refined prototypes over two weeks.” FACT: the trade outlet 3DPrint.com reported on August 13, 2025 that the motor otherwise replaced “costs just over \$300,000,” that the polymer prototype cost “approximately \$18,” and that the final part “cost \$131.21,” was delivered by Fleet Readiness Center Southeast Detachment Mayport, and “was also certified in-house.”

Assessment: the transferable part is the sequence — reverse-engineer the original, print a cheap polymer copy to prove the fit, bring in the co-located fleet readiness detachment to choose the production material, certify in house.

Assessment on the money: \$131.21 against \$300,000 is a real saving on one part, but it measures a catalogue problem rather than a manufacturing one. The release says the rotor cannot be bought on its own, so the \$300,000 is the price of the smallest thing the supply system would sell. One part is also one part: nothing here establishes a rate.

FACT: Military Times reported on June 20, 2025 that “recent NAVSEA guidance allows waterfront engineers to use additive manufacturing... to produce vessel parts and components classified as low-risk — meaning parts that are not vital to the safety and function of the ship,” and that the Forward Deployed Regional Maintenance Center Detachment Rota, working with Spanish allies, printed replacement eductors, or jet pumps, for the vacuum collection holding and transfer system — the shipboard sewage system — aboard the destroyer Arleigh Burke.

Assessment: that low-risk boundary is both the permission and the ceiling. A chilled water rotor and a sewage-system eductor are auxiliary items, and nothing in these releases describes a printed part entering a propulsion, weapons or pressure-boundary system. A limit on that read: the guidance is cited here only through Military Times’ paraphrase, and this desk has not identified or read the NAVSEA instruction that sets the classification, so what counts as low-risk is described rather than defined.

Bottom line: the adoption path is demonstrated at maintenance-centre level and it is cheap, but it runs only to parts the Navy classifies as low-risk, so the useful move is to find the auxiliary items on your own supply-blocked list and the technical data package — the drawings and specifications needed to make a part — that would let you print them.

Sources: NAVSEA, Aug 11, 2025; 3DPrint.com, Aug 13, 2025; Military Times, Jun 20, 2025; USNI News, Jun 23, 2026 {.sources}

BUSINESS PRACTICES & STRATEGY

The fifth public shipyard is back, four years after the Navy said no

Week 29 covered the FY2027 shipbuilding request and week 30 the \$1.85 billion study of foreign yards. This is the line that has moved since.

FACT: Breaking Defense reported on June 25, 2026 that Office of Management and Budget Director Russell Vought said the administration is “pushing hard for an additional public shipyard” and that “to do it at scale is something that is absolutely vital.”

FACT: the same report states the four public shipyards are Norfolk, Portsmouth, Puget Sound and Pearl Harbor, and that Vought pointed to the April decision to mothball the attack submarine Boise, “which hadn’t operated at sea in over a decade.”

The idea has been examined before, and the reasons it stalled are on the record.

FACT: Breaking Defense reported in May 2022 that a proposal to buy and build a fifth public shipyard in Ohio had been pitched to the Navy twice and rejected the first time “due to cost and policy concerns,” with the service still seeing issues with a revised submission, and that any Great Lakes plan faced “technical and legal hurdles.” FACT: the same report describes the Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Plan, first pitched in 2018, as an investment “the service expects to take two decades to complete,” with lawmakers annoyed that the Navy “low-balled its initial cost estimates” and that twenty years “is seen as just too long to wait.”

Assessment: the advocate has changed, not the obstacle. In 2022 the case came from outside the Navy and was refused on cost and policy; in 2026 it comes from the office that writes the budget, which moves who owns the cost objection without answering it. Nothing in the current reporting names a site, a design, a dry dock class or a date, and those are what a fifth yard actually consists of.

FACT: the Government Accountability Office reported in August 2020 that at the existing public shipyards it can take up to four years for an apprentice to reach journeyman and five to seven years to become fully trained.

Assessment: that training time is why a fifth yard matters long before any concrete is poured. On those figures a new public shipyard cannot grow its own journeymen inside its first several years, so it must hire trades that already exist, from the yards and private repair firms holding them today. Its opening decade therefore draws on the same journeymen everyone else employs, which is a competition for people before it is ever a change in workload.

Bottom line: watch for a named site rather than a named advocate, because the budget office wanting a fifth yard changes nothing on a waterfront until a location exists — and when one does, the first effect is on the wage bill for trades, not on the workload.

Sources: Breaking Defense, Jun 25, 2026; Breaking Defense, May 9, 2022; GAO-20-588, Navy Shipyards {.sources}

The Waterfront Brief is compiled weekly by the B2 vault's research engine from NAVSEA releases, USNI News, Naval News, GAO and congressional records, defense.gov, RAND, Defense News, Breaking Defense, The Maritime Executive, NSRP, ASNE, SNAME, arXiv, and academic publishers (15 sources staged this week; 1 quarantined as stale), then synthesized and labeled by hand. Scope: US shipbuilding, US Navy sustainment, and INDOPACOM partners; out-of-area items only for a direct, stated lesson. Freshness policy: every article's anchor source is under 12 months old; anything older appears only as dated context or a flagged exception. FACT means the named source says it, not that this desk has independently verified it. Corrections welcome; the staged sources are retained for audit.

UPCOMING EVENTS

Nearest first, filling the page (dates and registration deadlines exactly as organizers publish them). **Bold** marks a decision that closes inside the next 60 days.

Dates	Event	Register by	Why it matters
Aug 18-19, 2026	National Shipbuilding Research Program (NSRP) Electrical Technologies Panel Meeting, Pullman, WA (also virtual)	None published (Event link open)	The panel behind the fiber-optic switchboard-sensing pilot; tech transfer for electrical condition monitoring
Aug 24-25, 2026	NSRP Workforce & Compliance Panel Meeting, Pensacola, FL	In-person closed Aug 13, 2026	Cross-yard workforce practices while the Navy chases its 250,000-hire target
Aug 25-27, 2026	PSNS & IMF Sustainment Accelerator, Bremerton, WA (National Center for Manufacturing Sciences, with Puget Sound Naval Shipyard and Intermediate Maintenance Facility)	Not published	A public yard publishing the gaps it will be sold on: non-destructive testing, welding, portable power and machining, 3D scanning and metrology, confined-space monitoring, fibre-optic splicing, unmanned systems
Sep 22-24, 2026	Fleet Maintenance & Modernization Symposium 2026, Virginia Beach, VA (American Society of Naval Engineers, ASNE)	Early bird thru Aug 16, 2026	The flagship fleet-maintenance event for exactly this work
Sep 29 - Oct 2, 2026	Shipbuilders Council of America Fall Membership Meeting 2026, Washington, DC	Members only; none published	The surface-repair industrial base's Hill-and-Navy engagement window
Oct 28-29, 2026	Arctic Operations Symposium 2026, Baltimore, MD (ASNE)	Not published yet	Cold-region sustainment, hull and machinery readiness
Nov 16-17, 2026	Navy Procurement Outlook Summit, Reston, VA (Defense Leadership Forum)	Eventbrite open; no deadline published	Shipbuilding-plan and contracting priorities, with contracting-officer access
Dec 7-9, 2026	Technology, Systems & Ships / Combat Systems Symposium, Arlington, VA (ASNE)	Not published yet	Technology and ships exchange near the NAVSEA customer
Jan 26-28, 2027	Military Additive Manufacturing Summit, Tampa, FL	Tiers: Oct 2 / Dec 4; closes Jan 22	Metal and polymer print qualification and NAVSEA-spec adoption
Mar 23-25, 2027	NSRP All Panel Meeting 2027	"Coming soon" per NSRP	Where yard R&D ideas get socialized and teamed program-wide
Apr 12-15, 2027	RAPID + TCT 2027, Detroit, MI (SME)	None published	The largest additive show in North America; the market read behind the Danville pipeline

Beyond the printed window, rolling in as it approaches: Indo Pacific 2027 International Maritime Exposition (Nov 2-4, 2027).